

Royal Mile & Old Town - Kids

UK Family Tour

A City Built on a Volcano's Tail

Edinburgh's Old Town has the best origin story of any city street: it's built on a volcano. Three hundred and fifty million years ago, a volcano erupted here. Its plug of hard black rock became Castle Rock. Then, during the Ice Ages, a giant glacier — ice hundreds of meters thick — ground its way across this land. The hard volcanic rock split the ice like a boulder splits a river, protecting a long tail of softer ground behind it. The result is called a crag and tail: the castle sits on the crag, and the Royal Mile runs straight down the tail, from the castle at the top to Holyrood Palace at the bottom. The city grew along the tail because the sides were too steep — so instead of building outward, Edinburgh built UP. Look at the old tenement buildings, called “lands”: some were ten, twelve, even fourteen stories high, hundreds of years before elevators. These were basically the world's first skyscrapers. Rich and poor lived stacked in the same buildings — fancy folk in the middle floors, the poorest at the very top and very bottom. And all the narrow alleys running off the street? They're called closes and wynds. Each has a name and a story. Down the Mile you go — it's one Scottish mile, slightly longer than a regular one, and all downhill.

Related listening: The Old Town rides the volcano's tail; the climb takes you up the volcano itself. Coming up — “You Are Climbing a Volcano” (Arthur's Seat, Day 12).

Tell Me More: Reading the Old Town Like a Detective

Now that you know the shape of the city, here's how to read it. The closes — those narrow alleys — are numbered in the hundreds along the Mile, and their names are little history files: Fleshmarket Close (the meat market), Anchor Close (a tavern), Advocate's Close (a fancy lawyer lived there). World's End Close marks where the old city wall stood: for the poorest people of Edinburgh, who couldn't afford the toll to re-enter through the gate, the city gate genuinely was the end of their world — many never once left the walled city in their lives. There's a pub called The World's End there today, and brass markers in the road trace where the wall ran. Look up as you walk: the tall old buildings often show their history in layers — fancy carved doorways at the bottom, plainer stone above, and sometimes a date carved over a door from the fifteen or sixteen hundreds. Find the oldest date-stone you can; it's a good competition. Look down too: outside St Giles, brass cobbles spell things, and small plaques everywhere mark where famous people lived, were born, or — this being old Edinburgh — were executed. And one more word for your collection: the city's nickname Auld Reekie means Old Smoky — from the haze of coal smoke that hung over it, visible from far away, so travelers approaching would literally see the reek before the city. Look at today's clean air and consider how far the place has come.

The Rock Detective

Here's a job for your eyes. Stand on the Royal Mile and look for the big green hill that rises up behind the Old Town, like a sleeping lion. That's Arthur's Seat, and it's another old volcano, a cousin of the one under the castle. Beside it is a long reddish cliff called Salisbury Crags. Edinburgh isn't just built on one volcano, it's built in the middle of a whole family of them, all fast asleep for hundreds of millions of years.

Now here's the detective part. A little over two hundred years ago, a curious man named James Hutton used to walk out to those crags and stare at the rock. Everybody in his day believed the Earth was only a few thousand years old. But Hutton looked closely, the way a detective looks at clues, and he noticed something. Melted rock had squeezed in between the flat layers of older stone, like jam pushed between the pages of a book. For that to happen, the ground must have been squished and heated and folded over and over, incredibly slowly, for a length of time so enormous that a few thousand years was nowhere near enough.

So Hutton did something brave. He looked at these rocks and said the Earth must be almost unimaginably ancient, far older than anyone had ever dared to say. He couldn't put a number on it, but he could tell it was gigantic. He wrote that when he studied the rocks, he could find no sign of a beginning and no sign of an end.

He was right. Today we know the Earth is about four and a half billion years old, and Hutton is called the father of geology, which is the science of rocks and the story they tell. And that giant idea, the idea we now call deep time, was worked out partly by a man staring at a cliff you can see with your own eyes from this very street.

So while you walk the Mile, keep glancing at that green hill and that red cliff. You're not just looking at scenery. You're looking at one of the places where humans first figured out how old our planet really is. Not bad for a lump of old volcano.

Climbing Up a Land

Let's pretend, just for a minute, that you lived here three hundred years ago, in one of those towering buildings called lands. Ready? Here is your ordinary day, and it is a workout.

Your family's home is a single room near the very top, say the ninth floor. There is no lift, of course. To get up and down you use one narrow, twisting stone staircase called a turnpike stair, and every single family in the building shares it. So on your way down you squeeze past the wig-maker, the fishwife, a lawyer in a fine coat, and a family of ten, all using the same worn steps. Rich and poor, bumping shoulders, saying good morning, a whole little town stacked inside one staircase.

Now, you're thirsty. Where's the tap? There isn't one. There's no running water in the building at all. Water comes from a public well down in the street, and hauling it up nine floors is exhausting, so the city has a special job for that. Strong men called water caddies carry heavy barrels of water up the stairs, and you pay them for each delivery. Imagine paying someone just to bring you a bucket, then guarding it carefully because every drop climbed nine floors on someone's back.

Your one room is where the whole family eats, works, and sleeps, all together, lit at night by candles and a smoky fire. And remember, there's no bathroom either, which is where last night's shout of gurdyloo comes in.

Here's the part that surprises people. In most cities, the rich lived in one neighbourhood and the poor in another. But in old Edinburgh they lived in the same building, just on different floors. The comfortable middle floors, not too many stairs, not too close to the smelly street, were the fancy ones, where a judge or a merchant might live. The poorest families were squeezed into the damp cellars at the bottom and the freezing attics at the top.

So next time you're grumbling about climbing stairs, picture it. No lift, no tap, a candle in your hand, and a water caddy huffing up behind you with your bath. Look up at those tall old buildings again. Every one of those windows was somebody's whole world.

Gardyloo! The Smelliest City in Europe

Time for the gross part, and it's all true. Old Edinburgh had a big problem: tens of thousands of people packed into tall buildings, and no toilets, no sewers, no drains. So what did people do with their, um, buckets? At ten o'clock each night, they opened the window and threw everything into the street below — first shouting “Gardyloo!”, from the French for “watch out for the water.” Though it was not, mostly, water. If you were walking below, you had one second to shout back “Haud yer haund!” — hold your hand! — and jump. The mess flowed down the sloping streets, and the smell was so legendary that the city's nickname was Auld Reekie — Old Smelly. People walking at night would say the smell was so thick you could tell what floor a family lived on. This is also, some say, why gentlemen walked on the road side of the pavement, protecting the person beside them from splashes from above. And here's a bonus: some say the toilet word “loo” comes from gardyloo itself. Next time an adult on this trip says they're off to the loo, you may inform them they are speaking eighteenth-century Edinburgh sewage slang. You're welcome.

Tell Me More: Doctors, Body Snatchers and the Smell of Progress

The filth of old Edinburgh has a strange silver lining: it helped make this city a world capital of medicine. All that disease meant doctors were desperately needed, and Edinburgh's medical school became the best on Earth — students came from everywhere, including many of America's first doctors. But medical students needed to study real human bodies, and there weren't enough... legally. Enter the body snatchers: gangs who dug up fresh graves at night and sold the bodies to anatomy teachers, no questions asked. Families fought back with iron cages over graves — called mortsafes, you can still see them in Greyfriars Kirkyard — and watchtowers where relatives guarded new graves for weeks. Then, in 1828, two men named Burke and Hare skipped the digging entirely and murdered sixteen people to sell. When they were caught, Burke was hanged before a crowd of twenty-five thousand — and, in the era's idea of justice, his body was publicly dissected and his skeleton put on display at the university, where it remains to this day. A pocketbook was made from his skin; it's in a museum here. Edinburgh does not hide its dark bits. The good news ending: the scandal forced Parliament to change the law so medical schools got bodies legally, the graveyard cages became antiques, and the medical school stayed brilliant — it later produced the discoverer of chloroform anesthesia and the professor whose diagnostic tricks inspired his student Arthur Conan Doyle to invent Sherlock Holmes.

The Street Under the Street

Here is one of the strangest secrets in Edinburgh. Right under your feet, there is a whole street that has been frozen in the sixteen hundreds, buried in the dark, for nearly three hundred years. It's real, and you can go down into it.

It's called Mary King's Close. Long ago it was an ordinary busy alley of tall houses, full of families, shops and merchants. Then, around the seventeen fifties, the city decided to build a big grand building on top, the one that's now the City Chambers. But instead of knocking the old houses all the way down, the builders did something lazy and amazing. They chopped the tops off the buildings and used the lower floors as foundations, sealing the old street underneath like a secret in a drawer.

So it's still down there. Real doorways. Real rooms. Fireplaces where people once cooked. Little windows that now look out onto nothing but darkness and the underside of a modern building. When you visit, it's cold and quiet, and your voice goes strange, and you walk on the actual cobbles that people walked on four hundred years ago, deep beneath the traffic of today.

Now, being Edinburgh, there are spooky stories too, and here's where you get to be careful and clever. The story goes that a little girl called Annie once haunted one of the rooms, sad because she'd lost her doll. Visitors started leaving toys for her, and today one corner is piled with little gifts. It's a sweet story, and the toys are absolutely real, but nobody can actually prove a ghost, so keep that in your detective notebook under "lovely legends," not "facts."

There's a scarier tale too, that sick people were once sealed up alive down there during a plague. That one, happily, isn't true. The records show the city actually sent food and helpers to people who were ill and shut in. So it was grim, but not that cruel.

What's absolutely true, and honestly weirder than any ghost, is the buried street itself. A whole slice of old Edinburgh, tucked underneath the new one, waiting in the dark. As you walk the bright modern Mile, remember, there is another Edinburgh below you, keeping perfectly still.

The Stinky Lake and the Witch Test

You already know that at ten o'clock at night, all the horrible buckets got thrown into the street with a shout of gadyloo. But have you ever wondered where all that mess ended up? Gravity has the answer. It ran downhill.

And at the bottom of the hill, on the north side of the castle, there used to be a lake. It was called the Nor Loch, which just means the North Lake. Once upon a time it had been made on purpose, to help defend the castle, but over the years it turned into the city's giant open drain. Everything the city didn't want slid down into it, so instead of a sparkling blue lake, it became a still, green, evil-smelling soup. People threw in their rubbish, their dead animals, everything. If you can imagine the worst pond in the world, multiply the smell by a hundred, and that was the Nor Loch.

Now brace yourself, because the lake has a dark story too. In those days, people had a cruel and completely wrong idea. If they suspected a woman of being a witch, they would sometimes tie her thumbs to her toes and throw her into the loch. Here was their twisted test. If she floated, they said she was guilty and a witch. If she sank, she was innocent, but of course she might drown. It was a test nobody could really win, and it was terribly unfair. More than three hundred people are thought to have been ducked in that lake. It's one of the sad, shameful things humans used to do when they were frightened and didn't understand the world, and it's important to remember it really happened.

But this story has a genuinely happy ending, and you're going to walk right through it. A couple of hundred years ago, the city finally drained the disgusting lake away. And do you know what they turned that stinking, sorrowful place into? One of the most beautiful parks in Britain, called Princes Street Gardens, green and full of flowers, right below the castle. All the earth and rubble they dug out was piled up into a big ramp called the Mound, which is still there holding a road today.

So remember, when you stroll through those lovely gardens, you're walking over a spot that was once the smelliest, saddest lake in Edinburgh. The city cleaned up its worst place and grew a garden on top. That's a pretty good trick.

Spit on the Heart, Salute the Dog

Two Edinburgh traditions to collect today. First: near St Giles' Cathedral, look down. Set into the cobblestones is a heart shape made of granite blocks — the Heart of Midlothian. It marks the doorway of the Old Tolbooth, the city's dreaded prison, where executions happened outside the door. When the prison was demolished two hundred years ago, locals started spitting on the heart to show what they thought of the place. The tradition stuck — though today people say it's for good luck. So yes: this is the one place on the trip where you are officially allowed to spit in public. Aim for the middle of the heart. Mind your shoes. Second tradition: a short walk from the Royal Mile stands a small statue of a Skye terrier called Greyfriars Bobby. The story goes that when Bobby's owner, a night watchman named John Gray, died in 1858, Bobby refused to leave — he stayed near his master's grave in Greyfriars Kirkyard for fourteen years, becoming the whole city's dog. The Lord Provost himself paid Bobby's dog license so he couldn't be taken away as a stray. Historians argue about the details, but Edinburgh doesn't care: Bobby got a statue, and visitors rub his nose for luck. His nose is shiny gold from a million rubs. Add yours.

Tell Me More: More Street Legends

Three more Royal Mile legends to collect on your walk. One: near the castle end, you'll pass a church spire building called The Hub, and further down, outside a courtroom, a statue of the philosopher David Hume in a toga — one of the smartest humans who ever lived — whose big toe shines gold because students rub it for luck before exams. Philosophers would point out that Hume didn't believe in luck. Students rub it anyway. Two: John Knox House, one of the oldest houses on the Mile, all wooden galleries and painted ceilings — the fiery preacher John Knox may or may not have actually lived there, but the house is nearly five hundred years old and survives because of the legend that he did. Sometimes a good story protects a building better than a law. Three: the Mile's most famous small resident might be Wojtek — a statue in Princes Street Gardens nearby of a full-grown brown bear. Wojtek was a real bear, adopted as a cub by Polish soldiers in World War Two; he was officially enlisted as a soldier — rank: private, later corporal — so he could travel with his unit, learned to carry artillery shells during battle, loved beer and wrestling, and retired to Edinburgh Zoo, where his old army friends visited him and he'd perk up at Polish words. Edinburgh: a city where even the war memorials include a beer-drinking bear.

The Gentleman Burglar

Time to meet the most two-faced man in Edinburgh's history, and I mean that almost literally.

His name was William Brodie, though everyone called him Deacon Brodie, and in the daytime he was as respectable as a person could be. He was a skilled cabinetmaker, which means he built beautiful wooden furniture and cabinets. He was so trusted and important that he became a city councillor, one of the men who helped run Edinburgh, and the head of his group of tradesmen. Fine clothes, good manners, invited to all the best dinners. If you'd met him on the Mile, you'd have tipped your hat and thought, there goes a gentleman.

But here's the twist. At night, Deacon Brodie was a burglar.

And he was a clever one. You see, Brodie's respectable day job was the perfect disguise for his secret night job. Rich families hired him to build their cabinets and fit their locks, which meant he was welcomed right into their homes. While he was there, measuring their furniture and chatting politely, he would quietly press their door keys into a lump of soft wax to make a secret copy. Then, days later, in the dark, he'd let himself in with his copied key and rob them. Nobody suspected the nice Mr Brodie who had just been over for tea.

Why did such a well-off man steal? He had expensive secret habits. He loved gambling, he owed money, and he was secretly keeping two separate families who didn't know about each other. Keeping all those secrets cost a fortune, so he stole to pay for them.

It couldn't last forever. In seventeen eighty-eight one of his robberies went wrong, his gang was caught, and one of them told on him. Deacon Brodie was arrested and hanged, and the whole city was stunned that their trusted councillor had been a thief all along.

But here's the best part for a storyteller. Many years later, an Edinburgh boy named Robert Louis Stevenson grew up hearing about Deacon Brodie, the respectable man with the wicked secret life. That idea, one person hiding two completely different selves, stuck in his imagination. And when he grew up, he wrote one of the most famous scary stories in the world, the tale of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde, about a good man who turns into a monster. So keep an eye out on the Mile for a pub with Brodie's name on it. That double-life burglar became the seed of a monster in a book.

Was Bobby Really Real?

You've rubbed Bobby's shiny nose and heard the story, the loyal little dog who guarded his master's grave for fourteen years. It's a beautiful tale. But a good detective always asks one more question, so let's ask it. How much of the Bobby story is actually true?

The honest answer is, some of it may have grown a bit taller in the telling, and finding that out is its own kind of adventure.

A historian called Jan Bondeson went digging into the old records, the way Hutton dug into rocks, and he noticed some suspicious things. Right next to the churchyard where Bobby lived, there was a café and a graveyard keeper, and a famous, faithful little dog was very good for business. Crowds came to see Bobby, and while they were there, they bought food and paid the keeper. So Bondeson wondered, did those men make Bobby's story a little more perfect than it really was, to keep the visitors coming?

He found something even stranger. Fourteen years is a very long time for a small dog to live. Bondeson thinks the first Bobby may have died partway through, and been quietly swapped for a younger, cuter dog who looked similar. Two dogs, one legend. If that's true, no single dog waited fourteen years at all.

So does that ruin the story? Not really. Here's what we can say for certain. A stray dog really did live around that churchyard. The people of Edinburgh really did love him, so much that the city's leader paid his dog licence himself so nobody could take him away as a stray. And when a wealthy noblewoman had a little statue made in his honour, real crowds came to see it. The dog was real. The love was real. The statue is right there for you to touch.

It's just that some of the exact details, the neat fourteen years, the perfectly loyal single dog, are probably part legend, part true. And that's worth knowing, because it happens with lots of famous stories. People love a tale so much that they polish it, and round off the awkward corners, until it shines brighter than the plain facts ever did.

So go ahead, rub Bobby's golden nose. Just do it like a proper Edinburgh detective, half believing, half wondering, and enjoying the story either way.

Tell Me More: Half-Hangit Maggie

You're going to have lunch today in a big square called the Grassmarket, just below the castle, and it's a lovely, friendly place now, full of cafés and people. But long ago it had a much scarier job. This is where old Edinburgh held its public punishments, and enormous crowds, sometimes twenty thousand people,

would squeeze in to watch. So while you're munching your lunch, you're sitting in what used to be the most nervous spot in the whole city.

But I've saved you a brilliant story, and it has a happy ending, which is rare for this square. Back in seventeen twenty-four, a woman named Maggie Dickson got into terrible trouble and was sentenced to be hanged here in the Grassmarket. And she was hanged. Afterwards, everyone was quite sure she was gone. They took her down, put her in a wooden coffin, loaded it onto a cart, and set off to bury her back in her home village.

Now here's where it gets amazing. On the bumpy road out of town, the cart drivers stopped for a rest and a drink. And while they were sitting there, they heard a noise. A knocking noise. Coming from inside the coffin. You can just imagine their faces. They pulled off the lid, and there was Maggie, blinking up at them, alive. The bumping of the cart and the fresh cold air had woken her right up.

So what did the law do? This is the clever part. The judges scratched their heads and decided they couldn't hang her all over again, because her punishment had said hang her once, and they had. In fact, since everyone had already officially called her dead, they decided she was now like a brand-new person starting a fresh life. So they let her go free. Maggie lived another forty years after her own hanging, and everybody in Edinburgh knew her as Half-Hangit Maggie, the woman who came back. There's even a restaurant named after her in the square today. So look for her name while you eat, and give her a little cheer. She's the only person who ever beat the Grassmarket, and she got to brag about it for the rest of her life.

A Castle at One End, a Palace at the Other

Here's a game for the whole walk. This street you're on has a castle at one end and a palace at the other, and you're going to travel all the way from one to the other with your own two feet.

Look uphill first. Way up at the top, on its black cliff, is Edinburgh Castle, the mighty fortress. Think of that as the crown of the street, all walls and cannons and soldiers. Now turn and look downhill, the way you're walking. All the way down at the bottom is a royal palace called Holyrood, where the King or Queen still stays every summer. And here's a cool secret hiding in the name. Holyrood means holy cross. So the street runs from a crown at the top to a cross at the bottom, downhill all the way, like a giant slide with a castle on one end and a palace on the other.

Now, this looks like one street, but for hundreds of years it was really two different towns squished together, and there was a wall between them, right across the road. Up here you're in old Edinburgh. But once you cross a certain spot, you leave Edinburgh completely and walk into a separate little town called the Canongate, which had its own mayor, its own jail, and its own rules, until fairly recently in history. Imagine walking down one ordinary street and secretly crossing into a whole other town, without a single sign to tell you. You're about to do exactly that.

So keep your eyes busy. As you go down, notice how the street changes. Up top it's steep and crowded and old. Lower down it opens up and gets grander, because that's where rich lords built their houses to be close to the palace. And hold on to the shape of it in your head. A crown at the top, a cross at the bottom, and a whole tumbling mile of city in between. Ready? It's all downhill from here.

Related listening: Mary, Queen of Scots again: crowned at Stirling, at home, and in trouble, at Holyrood. Coming up — “A Nine-Month-Old Queen and the Man Who Tried to Fly” (Stirling Castle, Day 11).

Tell Me More: The Gate at the World's End

About two thirds of the way down the hill, you're going to cross a spot with a wonderfully spooky name. There's a pub there called The World's End, and it's called that for a real, and rather sad, reason. Stop and look down at the road, and you'll spot lines of shiny brass set into the cobbles, stretching right across the street. Those brass lines mark where a huge gate once stood. It was called the Netherbow Port, and it was the main door in the wall around old Edinburgh, a great stone gatehouse with a heavy portcullis that could crash down to lock the whole city shut.

Now for the shivery bit, and it's true. In the old days, when the city wanted to punish a traitor, they would sometimes stick the poor person's head on a spike right on top of this gate, for everyone to see as they walked in and out. Imagine strolling to the shops under a row of them. Yuck. The gate was finally knocked down about two hundred and sixty years ago because it was blocking the traffic, but its footprint is still there in the brass under your feet.

But why the World's End? Here's the sad part. To go out through that gate, and to come back in again, you had to pay money, a toll, every single time. And lots of people in old Edinburgh were far too poor to pay. So they simply never went out. For them, this gate really was the end of the world. Everything they would ever see in their whole lives was inside the wall, and out beyond the gate was a mystery they would never visit. That's why the alley here, and the pub, got the name the World's End.

So when you cross those brass lines, do something for me. Take one big step over them, and say, out loud if you like, that you just walked out of old Edinburgh and off the edge of somebody's whole world.

Because hundreds of years ago, for a lot of people, that is exactly what this spot was.

Tell Me More: The Palace, the Queen, and the Secret Stair

Right at the bottom of the Mile is the prize: a real royal palace called Holyroodhouse, where kings and queens have lived for five hundred years, and where the King or Queen still comes to stay for one whole week every single summer. Next to it stands something even older and stranger, a huge stone church with no roof at all, open to the sky and full of grass. That's Holyrood Abbey, and it's been a beautiful ruin for a very, very long time.

Inside the palace there's a tiny room with a very big, very scary story, so hold on tight. Long ago, a young queen called Mary, Queen of Scots lived here. One night in fifteen sixty-six, Mary was having supper in that little room with her friend and helper, a man named David. Suddenly a gang of angry men, led by Mary's own jealous husband, came stamping up a hidden, twisty staircase, burst into the room, grabbed David, and, well, they killed him, right there. Mary was going to have a baby at the time, and she must have been terrified. Ever since, guides have pointed to a dark patch on the floor and whispered that it's a stain from that terrible night. But here's the truth, detective. That stain isn't really old blood. Someone freshens it up with a bit of red paint now and then, just to give visitors a thrill. The sad story itself, though, is completely real.

The palace had happier nights too. About eighty years later, a dashing young prince nicknamed Bonnie Prince Charlie marched into Edinburgh, took over the palace, and threw glittering parties and balls here for a few weeks, with music and dancing, while he tried to win back a throne. It didn't work out for him in the end, but for those few weeks this palace was the most exciting place in all of Scotland.

And you've been collecting royal homes on this whole trip, haven't you? You saw the grand ones down south. Well, here's the Scottish one, right at the end of your downhill walk. So look up at the flagpole. If a special flag is flying, it means the King or Queen is actually inside, at home, having their tea, in the palace at the bottom of your street. Not bad for the end of a walk.

Tell Me More: The Biggest Show on Earth

You have arrived in the middle of the most show-off city in the world, so let me tell you what happens here in summer. Every August, this very street turns into the biggest arts festival on the whole planet. It's called the Fringe, and it began by accident. Way back in nineteen forty-seven, the city put on a big fancy festival and invited certain performers. But eight groups of actors turned up who hadn't been invited at all, and instead of going home in a huff, they found little halls and put their shows on anyway, around the edges. People started calling them the fringe, meaning the bits around the edge, and now, all these years later, that sneaky uninvited fringe has grown into the giant, and thousands of shows happen here every single day.

If you came back in August, this hill would be packed shoulder to shoulder with performers, all doing their thing at once, all trying to get you to come to their show. You'd see jugglers, a unicyclist wobbling past, someone escaping from chains, a person painted silver standing perfectly still like a statue, and everyone pushing little paper flyers into your hands. The street itself becomes the stage, and you get to be the crowd.

You're here in July, just before all that, but Edinburgh is already making music, because right now the city is holding its Jazz Festival, full of concerts in halls and pubs, and your family is going to some of it. That means you're not just visiting Edinburgh's festival season. You're actually part of it.

And later today, when your walk finishes near a big sloping road called the Mound, there's a festival carnival waiting there, with rides and games and lights, right next to the pretty gardens below the castle.

So the plan for today is a castle, then a whole mile of stories, and then a funfair. I'd call that a pretty excellent Sunday.

The City Made of Stories

Did you know a whole city can be famous for stories? This one is. Edinburgh was the very first place in the entire world to be called a City of Literature, which is a fancy way of saying a city of books and writers. So many brilliant storytellers have lived here that the whole town got a medal for it.

Tucked down one of the narrow closes off the Mile, in an old, old house with crow-step corners like little stairs built for a giant, there's a museum just for writers. It's free, and it's stuffed with treasures: a poet's actual writing desk, the very printing machine that printed some of the most famous Scottish books, and a ring that belonged to the man who wrote *Treasure Island*. Three writers are the stars of the house, and you'll be meeting one of them properly in a minute.

But here's the part I want you to hunt for. Just outside the museum, look down at the ground. Set right into the stones of the little courtyard are carved words, real lines written by Scottish poets, going back hundreds of years. It's called Makars' Court, and makar is an old Scottish word for a poet. It doesn't mean someone who writes, exactly. It means a maker, someone who makes things out of words, the way a carpenter makes things out of wood. Walk slowly, and read the ground like a giant page.

And now for a giggle, just for your family. Remember dinner last night, at that restaurant called Makars, with all the mashed potato? Well, now you know a secret about its name. Makar means poet. You ate your supper at the poets' table and didn't even know it. And it gets better. The most famous funny poem in all of Scotland is about, of all things, haggis, and it was first printed right here in this very neighbourhood, hundreds of years ago. So this city has been turning food, and mud, and castles, and everything else into stories for a very long time. It's a city made of stories. And you're walking straight through the middle of it.

Tell Me More: The Boy Who Drew *Treasure Island*

Let me tell you about a boy who grew up right here in Edinburgh and turned into one of the greatest adventure-storytellers who ever lived. His name was Robert Louis Stevenson, and when he was your age, he was often too sick to go out and play. He had weak lungs, and he spent heaps of time stuck in bed, coughing, in a chilly Edinburgh house, watching the world go by through the window.

His family had an amazing job, by the way. They built lighthouses, those tall towers that flash in the dark to warn ships off the rocks. His grandfather built one of the most famous and difficult lighthouses in the whole world, out on a reef that disappeared under the sea at high tide. Everybody expected young Robert to grow up and build lighthouses too. But Robert wanted to build something else. He wanted to build stories.

When he was stuck inside on dark evenings, he loved to watch a man called the lamplighter come down the street at dusk with a little ladder and a flame, lighting each gas lamp one by one, so the whole street slowly glowed to life. Robert loved that man so much that he wrote a poem about him, and gave him a name, Leerie, and wished the lamplighter would look up and give a nod to the little sick boy in the window. Imagine wanting so badly to be part of the world going by outside.

Now here's the best bit. When Robert was grown up, one rainy day he was playing with his young stepson, and together they drew a map of a made-up island, just for fun, with hills and coves and a big X to mark buried treasure. And Robert looked at that map, and a whole story came pouring out of him, about a boy, a pirate ship, and a sly one-legged pirate with a parrot, called Long John Silver. That story became *Treasure Island*, one of the most exciting books ever written, and it's a big reason pirates in films say things like arrr and follow maps with an X on them. He pretty much invented the treasure map.

So a sick boy at an Edinburgh window, who was supposed to build lighthouses, grew up to build pirates instead. Next time you draw a map of a make-believe place, remember, that is exactly how Treasure Island began. A rainy day, and a made-up map. You could do it too.